USER GUIDE

Detailed instructions for installing, configuring, preparing and saving encounters, using Scene and Combat presentation modes, tracking initiative on the DM and Player Displays, running visual timers, configuring Soundscapes, backing up data, and safely exiting enCounter

Version 0.2.0-alpha.2 • Timer + Soundscape + Saved Encounters + Initiative Auto-Follow + D&D 5E Conditions • MIT License • Alpha / Pre-release

> IMPORTANT: This guide documents enCounter v0.2.0-alpha.2, including Saved Encounters, Scene/Combat presentation, visual timers, Soundscapes, prepared audio cues, Player Display initiative centering, DM initiative Auto-Follow, structured D&D 5E conditions and Exhaustion, and Saved Encounter timer configuration. This is Alpha / pre-release software; features and screen layouts may continue to change. Export important data before updating to a newer Alpha build.

Existing screenshots are retained where they still illustrate the workflow. Clearly marked screenshot placeholders identify views that should be replaced with current v0.2.0-alpha.2 screenshots before final publication. The DOCX is formatted so those screenshots can be inserted or replaced directly in Microsoft Word or Google Docs.

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1. About enCounter

enCounter is a local-first TTRPG encounter, scene-presentation, initiative, timer, and Soundscape manager. The DM Console manages reusable characters, prepared and active encounters, scene/combat presentation, initiative, current-turn tracking, hit points, statuses, visual timers, local audio assets, encounter Soundscapes, and backups. A separate Player Display can be placed on a second monitor or TV for roleplaying scenes or combat while keeping private DM controls hidden.

- Runs locally on the computer; the packaged Windows and Linux versions do not require Python.
- Stores working application data in the browser using IndexedDB.
- Can write additional automatic JSON backups into the enCounter folder.
- Supports Generic TTRPG, Star Wars Saga Edition, D&D 5E, and a four-stat Custom system profile.
- Supports reusable Player, NPC, Enemy, and Creature Library entries.
- Supports a separate Player Display synchronized with the DM Console in the same browser profile, including a DM-controlled Hide / Show privacy screen for private encounter updates.
- Supports reusable Saved Encounters. Loading a Saved Encounter creates an active working copy so game-night changes do not overwrite the saved template unless the DM explicitly saves it.
- Supports Player Display phases for STAND BY, Scene presentation, and Combat presentation. Scene mode can show encounter artwork and visual timers without initiative information.
- Supports visual countdown timers in both Scene and Combat play, including Hourglass, Candle, and Sci-Fi Pixel Sequence skins.
- Supports encounter-bound Soundscapes with scene music, layered ambience, combat music/ambience, fade transitions, and prepared one-shot sound cues played from the DM computer.
- Player Display Combat mode automatically centers the active visible combatant as initiative advances.
- DM initiative Auto-Follow keeps the active combatant highlighted and brings that card into view when the current turn changes.

> **IMPORTANT:** Use one DM Console window at a time. Multiple DM Console windows can write to the same browser database and the most recent save can overwrite earlier changes.

1.1 Updating enCounter to the Current Build

Use this procedure when installing a newer portable enCounter release on a computer that already has an earlier build. The safest approach is to keep the previous installation intact until the new build has been started and verified.

> IMPORTANT: Before updating, wait for the DM Console to show SAVED, then use Data > Export Everything. Saved Encounters reference local images and audio rather than embedding those media files in the JSON export, so also keep a copy of any custom assets you want to retain.

1. In the current build, use Data > Export Everything and save the backup somewhere outside the enCounter application folder. If the permanent Library is especially important, a separate Library export can also be created.
2. Use Exit enCounter from the DM Console. Close the Player Display and any remaining enCounter browser tabs. Do not replace application files while the old enCounter process is still running.
3. Download the new Windows ZIP or Linux archive from the matching release. Verify the published SHA-256 checksum when one is provided.

4. Extract the new release into a new folder rather than copying it directly over the old installation. For example, keep the previous folder and create a separate folder for enCounter v0.2.0-alpha.2. This makes rollback much easier if a problem is found.
5. Copy your own media assets from the previous installation into the corresponding folders in the new build as needed. Common locations include assets/backgrounds/, assets/portraits/, and assets/sounds/. Do not copy the old programs/app application files into the new release.
6. If you want to retain disk-based backup/export history, copy the contents you need from data/backups/, data/exports/, and data/imports/ into the corresponding folders in the new installation. These folders are separate from the browser IndexedDB working database.
7. Start the new build using the same browser profile normally used for enCounter. On the same computer and browser profile, existing browser-stored data may remain available because the application continues to use the same local address, but the Export Everything backup should still be treated as the recovery copy.
8. Confirm the DM Console header shows the expected release version, for example ALPHA · v0.2.0-alpha.2. Then verify the Library, Saved Encounters, Player Display, and any custom media you rely on before deleting the older installation.
9. If Library or encounter data is missing, do not clear browser storage. Use Data to import/restore the Export Everything backup created before the update.

NOTE: A browser hard refresh or cache clear is not part of the normal update procedure. Use those steps only when the new application files are installed but the browser still displays an older version or older interface.

2. Downloading and Installing

2.1 Windows portable release

1. Open the official enCounter GitHub Releases page and download the Windows portable ZIP that matches the version you want to use.

2. If a SHA-256 checksum is published, verify it when practical before running the program.

3. Right-click the ZIP and choose Extract All. Extract the complete folder to a normal writable location such as Documents, Desktop, or a dedicated Games/Tools folder.

4. Open the extracted enCounter folder and double-click enCounter.exe. Keep enCounter.exe, _internal, programs, assets, data, and the documentation files together in the same folder.

> **CAUTION:** Do not place the portable build under Program Files unless you intentionally manage Windows permissions there. enCounter writes backups and imported assets inside its own folder and therefore works best in a normal writable user folder.

> **NOTE:** The Alpha executable may be unsigned. Windows SmartScreen can show an unknown-publisher/reputation warning. Only continue when the file came from the official project release and you trust the download.

2.2 Linux portable release

1. Download the Linux tar.gz from the matching GitHub Release.

2. Extract the complete archive into a writable folder under your home directory.

3. Run the enCounter executable from the extracted folder. Depending on your desktop environment, you may be able to double-click it.
4. If Linux reports that the file is not executable, open a terminal in the folder and run chmod +x enCounter, then run ./enCounter.

> **IMPORTANT:** Do not move only the executable. The portable program depends on the accompanying _internal, programs, assets, and data folders.

3. Starting enCounter and Startup Recovery

When enCounter starts, it launches a local server on 127.0.0.1:5500 and opens the DM Console in your default browser. The server is local to your computer; it is not intended to be reachable from other computers.

3.1 First launch

1. Start enCounter from the extracted portable folder.
2. Wait for the browser to open the DM Console.
3. **Confirm the header shows the expected version: ALPHA · v0.2.0-alpha.2.**
4. Choose your preferred Settings mode before building a permanent Library if you want to expose additional modules such as Abilities, Resources, or a condition track.

3.2 Resume Last Encounter prompt

If enCounter finds a meaningful saved encounter, startup displays a recovery prompt. You can resume the saved encounter or begin a new one. Choosing New Encounter does not delete the permanent Library, assets, presets, settings, or recovery snapshots.

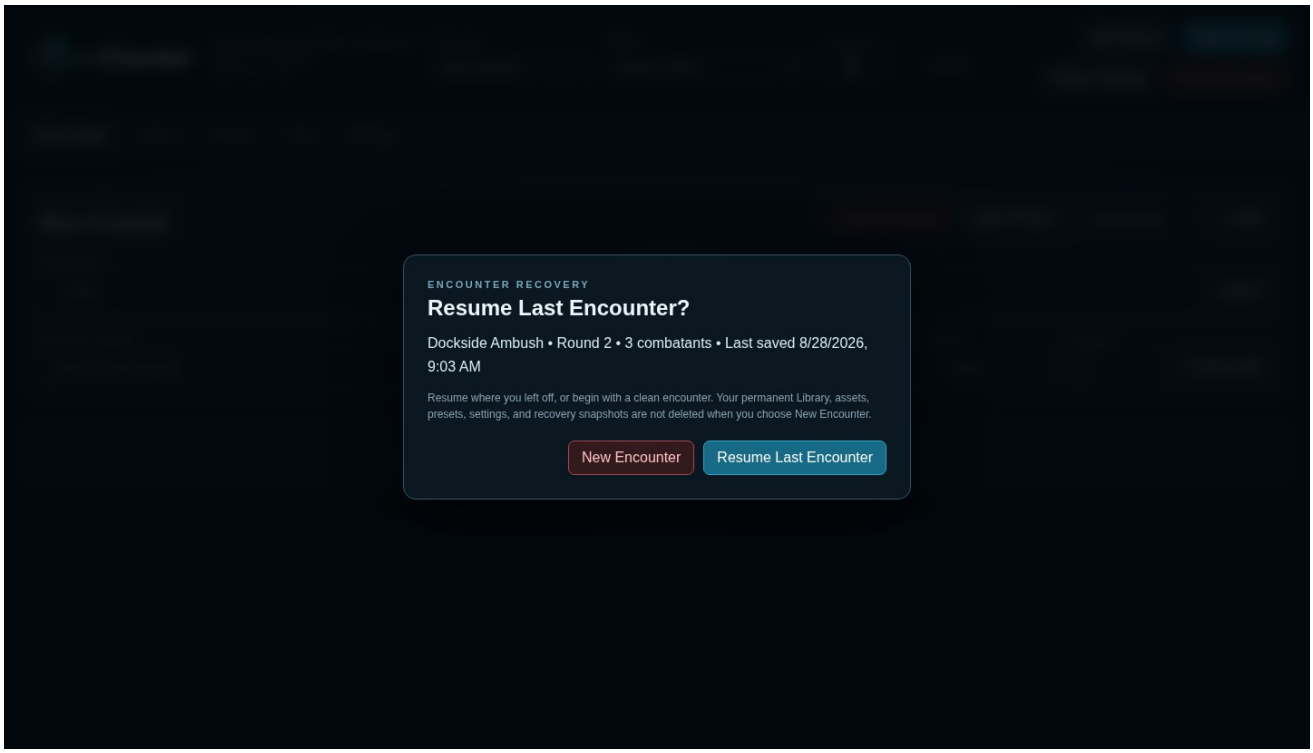


Figure 1 - Startup recovery prompt for a previously saved encounter.

1. Choose Resume Last Encounter when returning to an unfinished session.
2. Choose New Encounter when the previous encounter is no longer needed. enCounter creates a recovery snapshot of the previous meaningful encounter before replacing it.

4. DM Console Overview

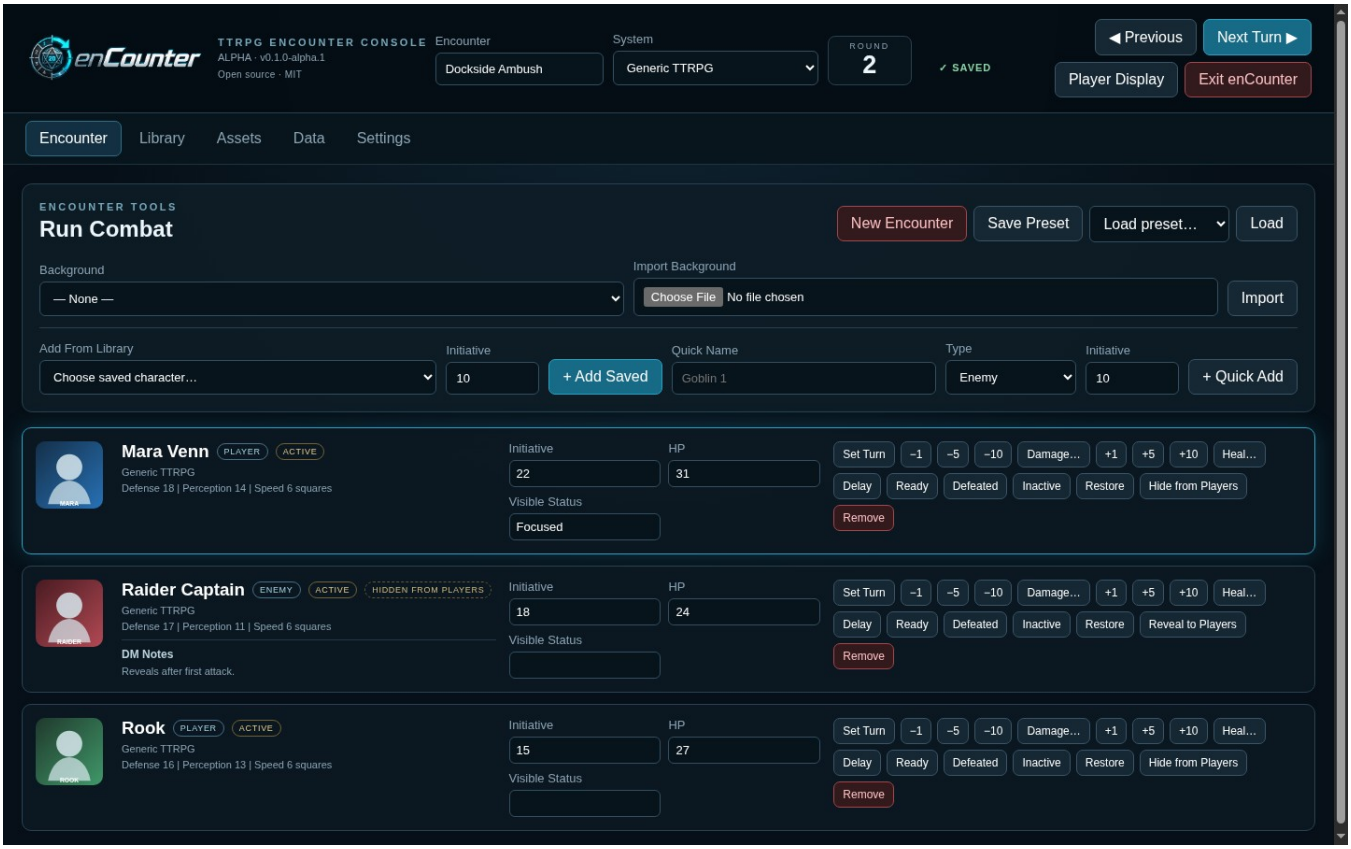


Figure 2 - DM Console Encounter screen with sample combatants.

4.1 Header controls

Control	Purpose
Encounter	Names the active encounter. Changes are saved when the field changes.
System	Selects Generic TTRPG, Star Wars Saga Edition, D&D 5E, or Custom.
ROUND	Shows the current round. enCounter updates it as initiative wraps.
SAVED / SAVING	Shows whether a browser save is currently in progress.
Previous / Next Turn	Moves backward or forward through eligible initiative combatants.

Control	Purpose
Start / Hide / Show Player Display	Starts the separate player-facing display. Once connected, the same button hides the Player Display behind a STAND BY privacy screen or shows the latest encounter state again.
Exit enCounter	Attempts a final external backup, then stops the local server.

4.2 Main navigation

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Timer opens the visual timer editor and live countdown controls. Soundscape opens the detailed audio setup for the currently loaded encounter.

- Encounter - build and run the current encounter.
- Library - create and manage permanent reusable combatants.
- Assets - import and review portraits, backgrounds, tokens, and supported icons.
- Data - export, import, restore, request persistent storage, and restore recovery snapshots.
- Settings - select a tracker mode, enable modules, control automatic external backups, and define a custom ruleset.

5. Settings and First-Time Configuration

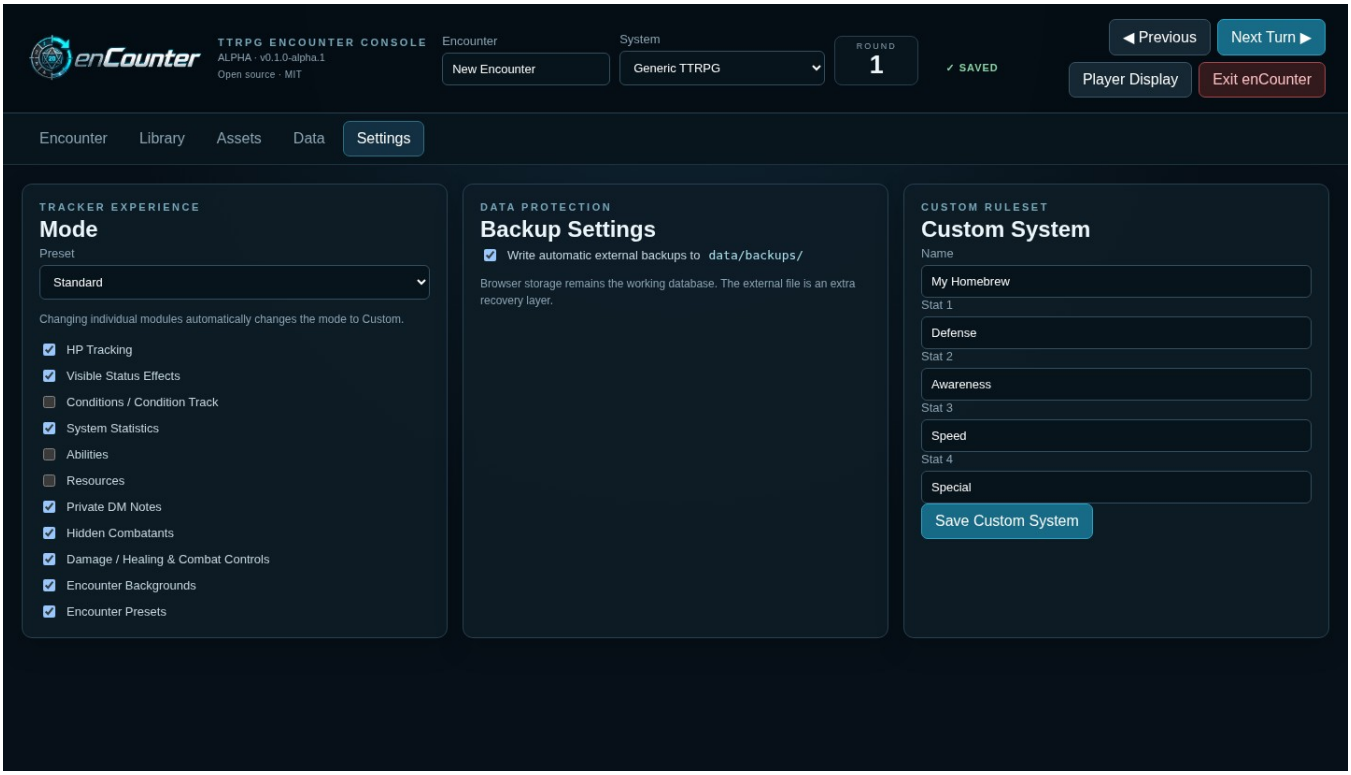


Figure 3 - Settings screen showing modes, automatic backup, and a Custom system.

5.1 Tracker modes

Modes control which combat-management modules are visible. Changing an individual module automatically changes the mode to Custom.

Mode	Best for	Default behavior
Simple	Initiative-only play	Backgrounds only; hides HP, statuses, stats, combat controls, notes, hidden-combatant controls, abilities/resources, and presets.
Standard	Typical encounter tracking	HP, visible status, system stats, DM notes, hidden combatants, damage/healing controls, backgrounds, and presets.
Advanced	Full feature set	Enables every available module, including conditions, abilities, and resources.
Custom	Tailored setup	Uses the exact module checkboxes you choose.

5.2 Automatic external backups

When Write automatic external backups is enabled, important saves schedule a JSON backup to data/backups/ in the portable enCounter folder. Browser IndexedDB remains the primary working database; the disk backup is an additional recovery layer.

5.3 Custom System

1. Choose Settings.
2. Enter a custom system Name.
3. Define labels for Stat 1 through Stat 4.
4. Click Save Custom System.
5. When creating Library entries or encounters, choose Custom as the system.

> **TIP:** Configure the Custom system before creating many Custom-system Library entries so the saved labels are consistent.

6. Creating and Managing the Library

The Library is permanent reusable data. Adding a Library entry to an encounter creates a temporary encounter copy, so damage, initiative changes, statuses, and resource use during combat do not alter the permanent Library record.

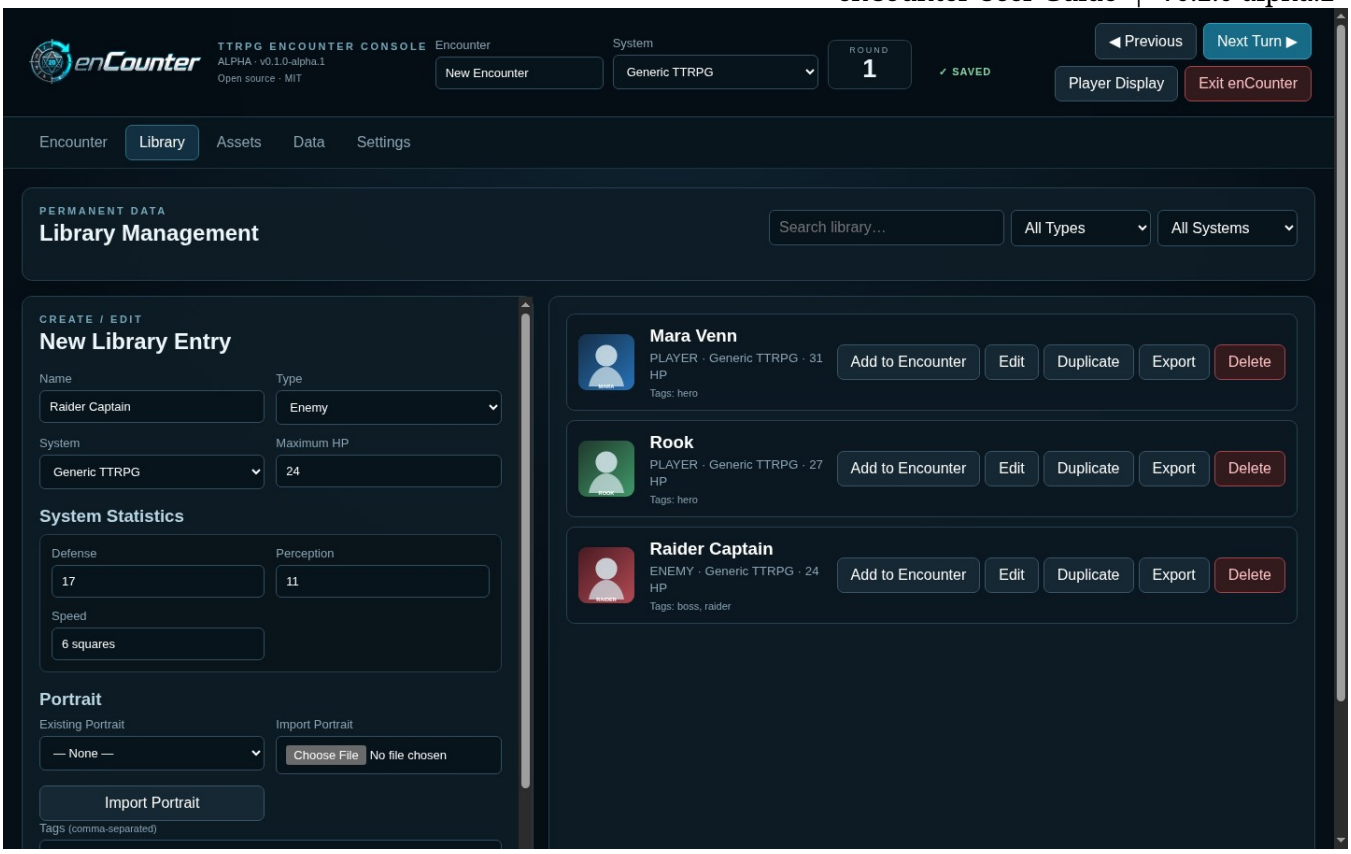


Figure 4 - Library Management with sample Players and an Enemy.

6.1 Create a Library entry

1. Open Library.
2. Enter the Name.
3. Choose Type: Player, NPC, Enemy, or Creature.
4. Choose the System. The System Statistics fields update to match the selected system.
5. Enter Maximum HP if HP tracking will be used.
6. Complete any displayed System Statistics.
7. Choose an existing Portrait or use Import Portrait to add a PNG, JPEG, or WebP image.
8. Optionally enter Tags separated by commas. Tags are searchable.
9. Optionally enter Private DM Notes. These are never shown on the Player Display.
10. If Abilities are used, enter one per line in the format Name | Uses | Description. Leave Uses blank for an unlimited ability.
11. If Resources are used, enter one per line in the format Name | Current | Max.
12. Click Save Library Entry.

Examples for structured fields

Ability example: Battle Cry | 1 | Grant nearby allies a temporary bonus

Resource example: Charges | 3 | 3

> **NOTE:** Abilities and Resources are stored even when the current display mode does not show those modules. Switch to Advanced or enable the modules in Custom mode to use them during combat.

6.2 Search and filter

Use Search library to search names, tags, and private notes. Use the Type and System filters to narrow the visible Library cards.

6.3 Library card actions

Action	Result
Add	Prompts for initiative, adds a temporary copy to the current encounter, and returns to Encounter.
Edit	Loads the permanent entry into the editor.
Duplicate	Creates a new permanent copy named “<name> Copy.”
Export	Downloads a JSON file containing only that one Library entry.
Delete	Permanently deletes the Library entry after confirmation. Existing encounter copies are not the permanent Library record.

7. Managing Portraits, Backgrounds, and Assets

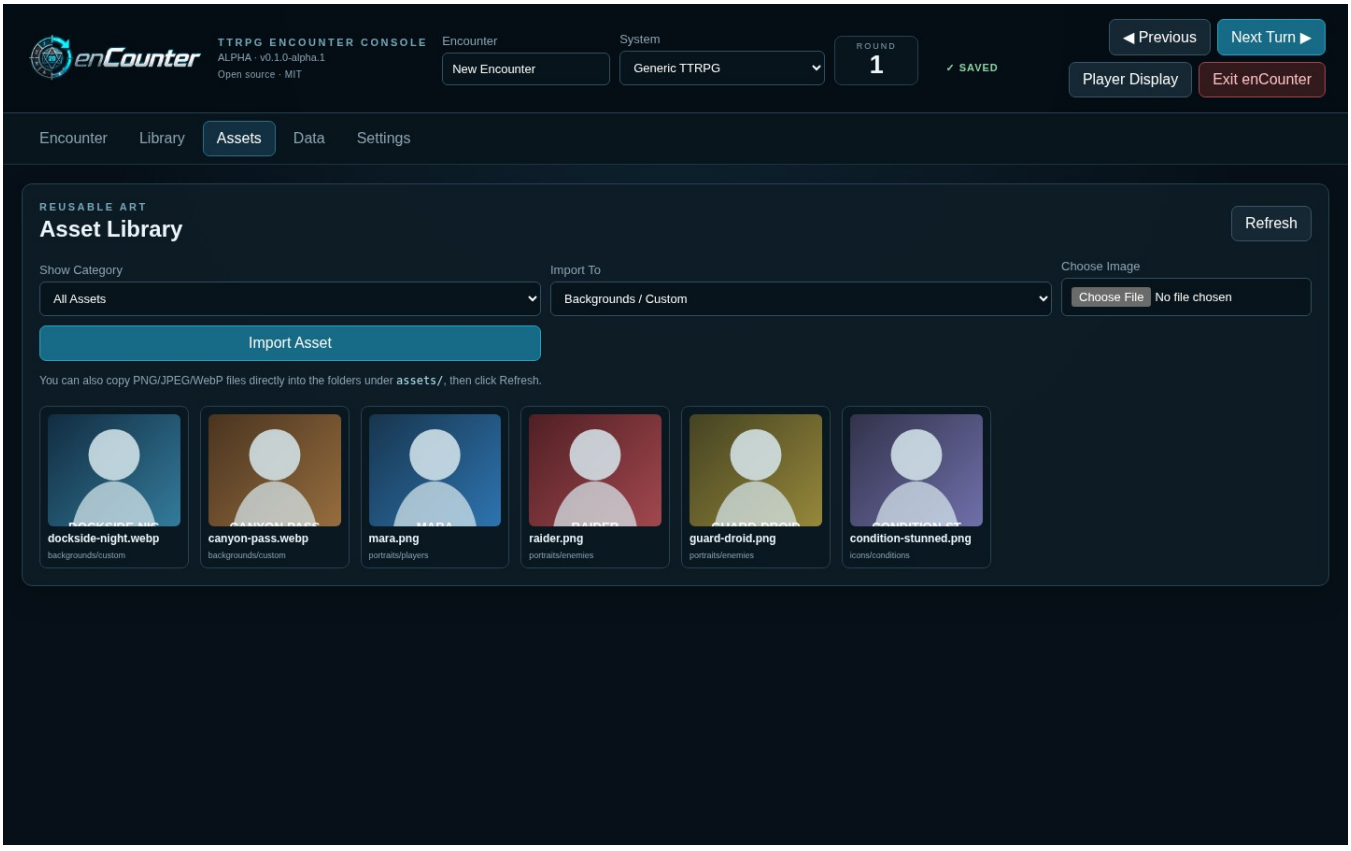


Figure 5 - Asset Library with sample reusable art.

7.1 Supported image files

- PNG
- JPEG / JPG
- WebP
- Maximum upload size: 10 MB per image

7.2 Import from the Assets screen

1. Open Assets.
2. Choose the destination category under Import To.
3. Choose an image file.
4. Click Import Asset.
5. Use Show Category to filter the grid if needed.

7.3 Copy files directly into the portable folder

You can also copy supported image files into the appropriate subfolder under assets/ while enCounter is not writing that file. Return to Assets and click Refresh so the application rescans the folders.

7.4 Portraits

The Library editor can import a portrait directly. enCounter chooses a portrait folder based on the Library type: Players, NPCs, Enemies, or Custom.

7.5 Encounter backgrounds

An encounter can now use separate Scene Image and Combat Background selections. They may point to the same image or to different artwork. Scene Image is intended for roleplaying/exploration presentation; Combat Background is used when Combat mode is active.

7.6 Audio assets

Audio is stored under assets/sounds/ and remains local to the enCounter folder. Supported categories are music, ambience, sound effects, and custom audio.

Supported audio formats are MP3, OGG, WAV, and FLAC. MP3 or OGG is recommended for long music and ambience files; WAV is suitable for short sound effects when file size is acceptable.

Audio can be imported from the Soundscape screen or through the Assets screen. After import, the file becomes available in Soundscape selectors for the currently loaded encounter.

On the Encounter screen, choose a saved Background from the list or use Import Background. Backgrounds are shown behind the Player Display and remain part of the encounter configuration.

8. Creating an Encounter

8.1 Name and system

1. Open Encounter.
2. Enter a descriptive encounter name.
3. Choose the encounter System before adding combatants whenever possible.
4. Optionally select or import a background.

> **IMPORTANT:** The Add From Library list only shows Library entries whose system matches the active encounter system. Changing the encounter system later does not automatically convert existing combatants to a new system profile.

8.2 Add a saved Library combatant

1. Choose a character from Add From Library.
2. Enter the initiative value.
3. Click + Add Saved.
4. The combatant is copied into the encounter. Changes made during combat do not change the permanent Library entry.

8.3 Quick Add

1. Enter a Quick Name.
2. Choose the Type.
3. Enter initiative.
4. Click + Quick Add.

Quick Add creates only an encounter combatant. It does not add a permanent Library entry.

8.4 Encounter presets

Presets are reusable encounter templates. They are useful for recurring enemy groups, standard patrols, or frequently used scenarios.

1. Build the encounter roster and optional background.
2. Click Save Preset and enter a preset name.
3. Later choose the preset from Load preset and click Load.
4. Confirm that the current encounter may be replaced.

> **NOTE:** When a preset is saved or loaded for a new fight, transient combat values are reset: initiative returns to 10, HP returns to maximum when available, visible status/condition state is cleared, combatants become active, and hidden/delayed/readied flags are reset.

8.5 New Encounter

Click New Encounter to clear the active combat roster. A meaningful previous encounter is stored as a recovery snapshot first. The permanent Library, assets, presets, settings, and snapshots remain available.

8.6 Saved Encounters and working copies

Saved Encounters are reusable prepared encounter templates. Use Save As... to create a new Saved Encounter from the current working encounter. Use Save to update the Saved Encounter currently associated with the working copy.

Load creates an active working copy. Initiative changes, damage, added reinforcements, audio playback state, timer use, and other game-night changes occur in the working encounter and do not automatically overwrite the saved template.

Duplicate creates another Saved Encounter that can be modified independently. Delete removes the selected Saved Encounter after confirmation; it does not delete reusable character Library records or media assets.

> TIP: During preparation, configure participants, Scene Image, Combat Background, Soundscape, and any planned timer settings, then explicitly Save the encounter. During play, use Save only when you intentionally want to update the reusable template.

8.7 Scene and Combat presentation

The Encounter screen separates roleplaying presentation from initiative. Show Scene changes the Player Display to Scene mode: the selected Scene Image can be shown without initiative cards, round information, Current Turn, or Next Turn.

Start Combat changes the encounter to Combat phase and uses the Combat Background. It establishes the first current combatant, brings that combatant into view on the DM Console, and centers the current visible combatant on the Player Display. If configured, enCounter also transitions from scene audio to combat audio. End Combat can return the encounter to Scene phase and optionally restore scene audio.

Hide Player Display always returns the player-facing screen to STAND BY for private DM preparation.

8.8 Encounter live controls

The Encounter tab is intended to be the game-night control center. Use Scene Audio to start the prepared scene Soundscape, Start Combat to begin the combat transition, End Combat to return to Scene, Stop Audio for immediate silence, and the Prepared Cues buttons for one-shot effects such as alarms, explosions, doors, transmissions, creature sounds, or other prepared effects.

[SCREENSHOT PLACEHOLDER] Replace with a current v0.2.0-alpha.2 Encounter tab showing Saved Encounter controls, Scene/Combat controls, Prepared Cues, and the active combatant.

Figure 10 - Encounter screen: Saved Encounter, Scene/Combat controls, and Prepared Cues.

9. Running Combat

9.1 Initiative and turns

Combat is now an explicit encounter phase. A loaded encounter may remain in Prepared or Scene phase for roleplaying before initiative is revealed. Use Start Combat when the fight actually begins.

Combatants are automatically sorted by initiative from highest to lowest. The current combatant receives a highlighted card, and the same current-turn state is shared with the Player Display.

- Next Turn advances to the next eligible combatant.
- Previous moves backward through eligible initiative.
- Round increases when moving forward wraps from the bottom of the eligible order back to the top.
- Round never goes below 1 when moving backward.
- Defeated, Inactive, Delayed, and Readied combatants are skipped by normal initiative advancement.
- Set Turn can make a combatant active and immediately set that combatant as the current turn.

9.2 DM initiative Auto-Follow and synchronized current turn

The DM Console follows the current initiative order so the active combatant stays easy to locate during encounters that extend beyond the visible portion of the combatant list.

DM Auto-Follow brings the current combatant into view when:

- Start Combat establishes the first current combatant.
- Next Turn advances to the next eligible combatant.
- Previous moves backward to the previous eligible combatant.
- Set Turn manually makes a combatant the current turn.
- Trigger / Resume causes a Delayed or Readied combatant to resume and take the current turn.

> Auto-Follow occurs only when the active turn changes. Damage/healing, direct HP edits, statuses, Condition Track changes, resources, notes, Hide/Reveal actions, and other non-turn edits do not force the DM screen back to the active combatant.

[SCREENSHOT PLACEHOLDER - DM INITIATIVE AUTO-FOLLOW] Capture the DM Console during a long initiative order with the active combatant highlighted and scrolled into view.

Figure 10A - DM Console following the active combatant in initiative.

9.3 Edit initiative, HP, and visible status

Edit Initiative directly on a combatant card; enCounter re-sorts the cards. When HP tracking is enabled, the HP field can be edited directly. When Visible Status Effects is enabled, comma-separated statuses are shown as badges on the Player Display.

9.4 Damage and healing

When combat controls and HP are enabled, use the -1, -5, -10 and +1, +5, +10 buttons for common adjustments. Damage… and Heal… prompt for a custom amount. Healing is capped at Maximum HP when a maximum is defined, and HP cannot fall below 0.

9.5 Condition Track

When the Conditions module is enabled and the combatant uses Star Wars Saga Edition, a Condition Track selector is available: Normal, -1, -2, -5, -10, or Helpless. Non-Normal values appear on the Player Display as a CT badge.

9.6 D&D 5E Conditions and Exhaustion

When the Conditions module is enabled and a combatant uses D&D 5E, use Add 5E Condition… to apply one or more standard conditions. Active conditions appear as removable chips on the DM combatant card and as condition badges on the Player Display. Supported conditions include Blinded, Charmed, Deafened, Frightened, Grappled, Incapacitated, Invisible, Paralyzed, Petrified, Poisoned, Prone, Restrained, Stunned, and Unconscious.

Exhaustion is tracked separately because it has a numeric level. Choose None or Level 1 through Level 6. A non-zero Exhaustion level is shown to players as an Exhaustion badge.

> IMPORTANT: Visible Status remains available for free-form or campaign-specific effects such as Concentrating, Blessed, Hunter's Mark, or other custom states. When a reusable Saved Encounter or preset is loaded as a fresh working copy, structured 5E conditions, Exhaustion, Visible Status, and other transient combat state are reset rather than carried forward from the previous session.

9.7 Delay, Ready, Defeated, Inactive, and Restore

Control	Effect
Delay	Marks the combatant Delayed and removes it from normal initiative advancement.
Ready	Marks the combatant Readied and removes it from normal initiative advancement.
Trigger / Resume	Returns a Delayed or Readied combatant to Active and sets it as the current turn.
Defeated	Marks the combatant Defeated. The Player Display dims it and labels it defeated.
Inactive	Marks the combatant Inactive. It remains visible but is skipped by normal initiative.
Restore	Returns a non-active combatant to Active without necessarily taking the turn immediately.
Remove	Removes the temporary combatant from the encounter only; the permanent Library entry is not deleted.

10. Hiding and Revealing Combatants

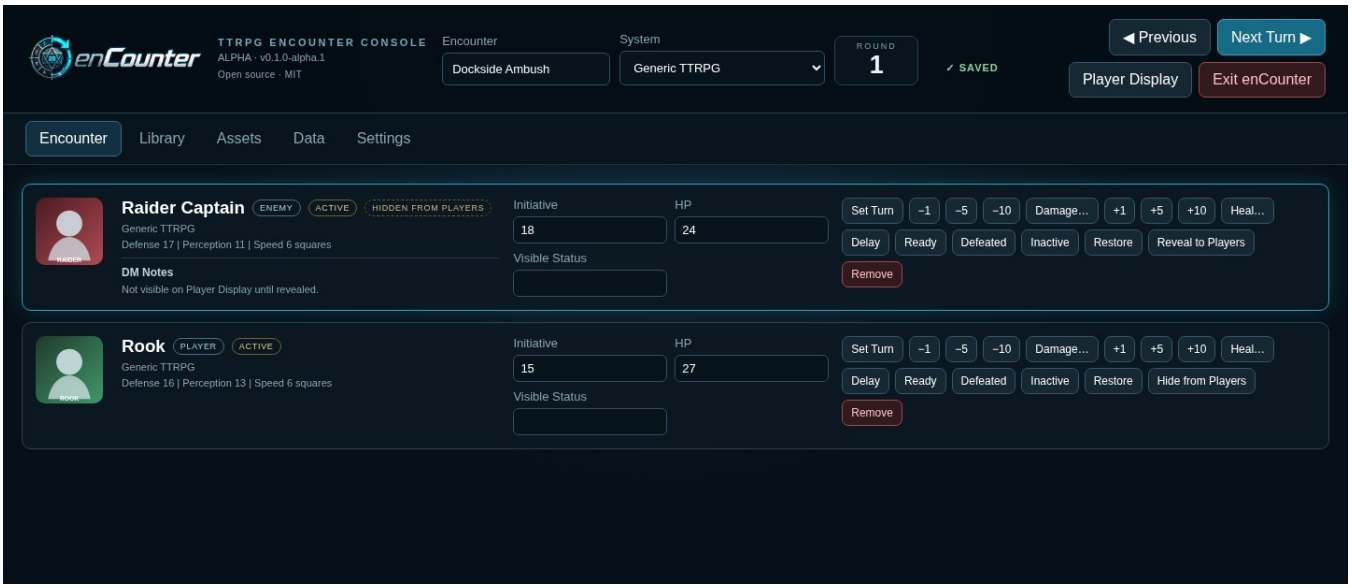


Figure 6 - A hidden enemy remains visible to the DM and is marked Hidden from Players.

When Hidden Combatants is enabled, each DM combatant card has Hide from Players / Reveal to Players.

1. Click Hide from Players before the combatant should be known to the players.
2. The DM card remains fully visible and gains a Hidden from Players badge.
3. The hidden combatant is completely omitted from the Player Display: no card, name, portrait, current-turn name, or next-turn name is shown.
4. When the enemy or NPC becomes known, click Reveal to Players. The card immediately reappears in its normal initiative position.

> **TIP:** This is useful for ambushes, invisible enemies, secret reinforcements, and creatures that have not yet entered the scene.

11. Using the Player Display

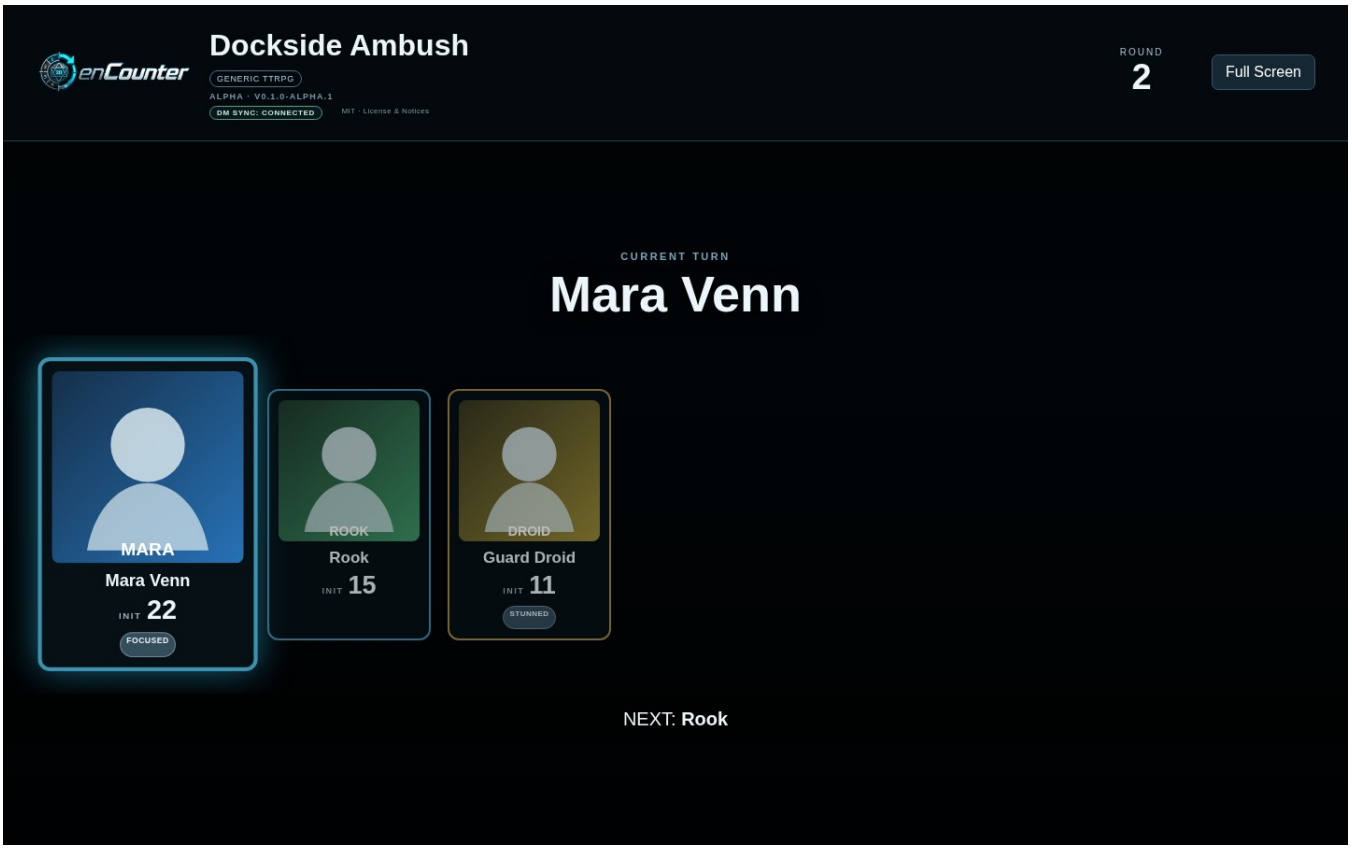


Figure 7 - Player Display example. In Combat mode, v0.2.0-alpha.2 automatically centers the current visible combatant as initiative advances.

11.1 Open the display

1. Keep the DM Console open.
2. Click Start Player Display in the DM header.
3. A separate browser window opens and begins on a protected STAND BY screen while it confirms the DM Console state.
4. Confirm the DM SYNC indicator becomes CONNECTED. The DM button changes to Hide Player Display.
5. Move the Player Display window to the monitor or TV used by the players.
6. Click Full Screen on the Player Display when desired.

11.2 Hide and show the Player Display

Use the same DM header button to temporarily protect the player-facing screen while you make private encounter changes. The Player Display window stays open on the TV or second monitor, so you do not need to reposition it or leave Full Screen.

1. Click Hide Player Display. The player-facing screen immediately changes to the enCounter STAND BY privacy screen.

2. Make any private DM changes you need, such as correcting initiative, adding or removing reinforcements, changing combatants, or preparing a surprise. enCounter continues receiving the newest encounter state internally, but those changes are not rendered for the players.

3. When the encounter is ready, click Show Player Display. The privacy screen is removed and the Player Display immediately renders the latest complete encounter state.

4. After the display is visible again, the DM button returns to Hide Player Display.

> TIP: Hide Player Display is ideal when adjusting initiative order, adding secret reinforcements, correcting setup mistakes, or making any change that the players should not watch being prepared.

If the Player Display window is closed manually, enCounter detects that the window is gone and returns the DM button to Start Player Display.

11.3 Same-browser-profile requirement

Player Display synchronization uses BroadcastChannel with a localStorage fallback. The DM Console and Player Display must be in the same browser profile. Using Start Player Display from the DM Console satisfies this requirement because the player-facing window is opened from the DM page.

> **CAUTION:** Opening the Player Display in a different browser, a different browser profile, or a private/incognito session will not share the local synchronization channel. The display will show DM SYNC: DISCONNECTED rather than silently appearing connected.

11.4 What players see

- Encounter name and system
- Round number
- Current visible eligible combatant
- Visible initiative cards sorted by initiative, with the current visible combatant automatically centered as turns advance
- Next visible eligible combatant
- Portraits
- Visible status badges
- Star Wars Saga Edition condition-track badge when applicable
- D&D 5E condition and Exhaustion badges when applicable
- Defeated, Inactive, Delayed, and Readied state badges
- Encounter background

Private DM notes, damage/healing buttons, resource controls, hidden combatants, and other DM management controls are not shown.

11.5 Second monitor or TV - Windows

1. Connect the monitor or TV.
2. Press Windows + P and choose Extend rather than Duplicate.
3. Click Start Player Display from enCounter.
4. Drag the Player Display window onto the second screen.
5. Use Full Screen.

11.6 Second monitor - Linux

Use your desktop environment display settings to extend the desktop, then move the Player Display window onto the second display and use Full Screen.

11.7 Player Display modes

The Player Display now has three practical presentation states: STAND BY, Scene, and Combat.

STAND BY hides encounter information while the DM prepares privately. Scene is for roleplaying and exploration: it can show the encounter Scene Image and an optional visual timer without revealing initiative. Combat shows the normal initiative interface, current/next turn information, visible combatants, statuses, and the Combat Background.

Scene Audio does not have to be tied to visibility. The DM can start ambience while the Player Display remains on STAND BY, reveal the Scene later, or show the Scene without starting audio.

11.8 Combat initiative centering

In Combat mode, the Player Display uses the same current-turn state as the DM Console. When the active turn changes, the current visible combatant is highlighted and automatically centered in the initiative display.

This keeps the acting character or creature visible during larger encounters without requiring the DM or players to manually reposition the initiative track.

> Hidden combatants remain completely omitted from the Player Display until Reveal to Players is selected. If the DM current turn is on a hidden combatant, player-facing current/next information continues to use only eligible visible combatants.

[SCREENSHOT PLACEHOLDER - PLAYER DISPLAY INITIATIVE CENTERING] Capture Combat mode with enough visible combatants to demonstrate the current combatant centered in the initiative track.

Figure 11A - Player Display automatically centering the active visible combatant.

11.9 Timers on the Player Display

A timer marked Show timer to players can appear in either Scene or Combat mode. It is hidden while the Player Display is on STAND BY. The DM can choose whether players see the exact numeric countdown or only the visual timer skin.

[SCREENSHOT PLACEHOLDER] Capture a Player Display Scene-mode example. No initiative or combat information should be visible.

Figure 11 - Player Display in Scene mode with roleplaying artwork and optional visual timer.

12. Backups, Exports, Imports, and Recovery

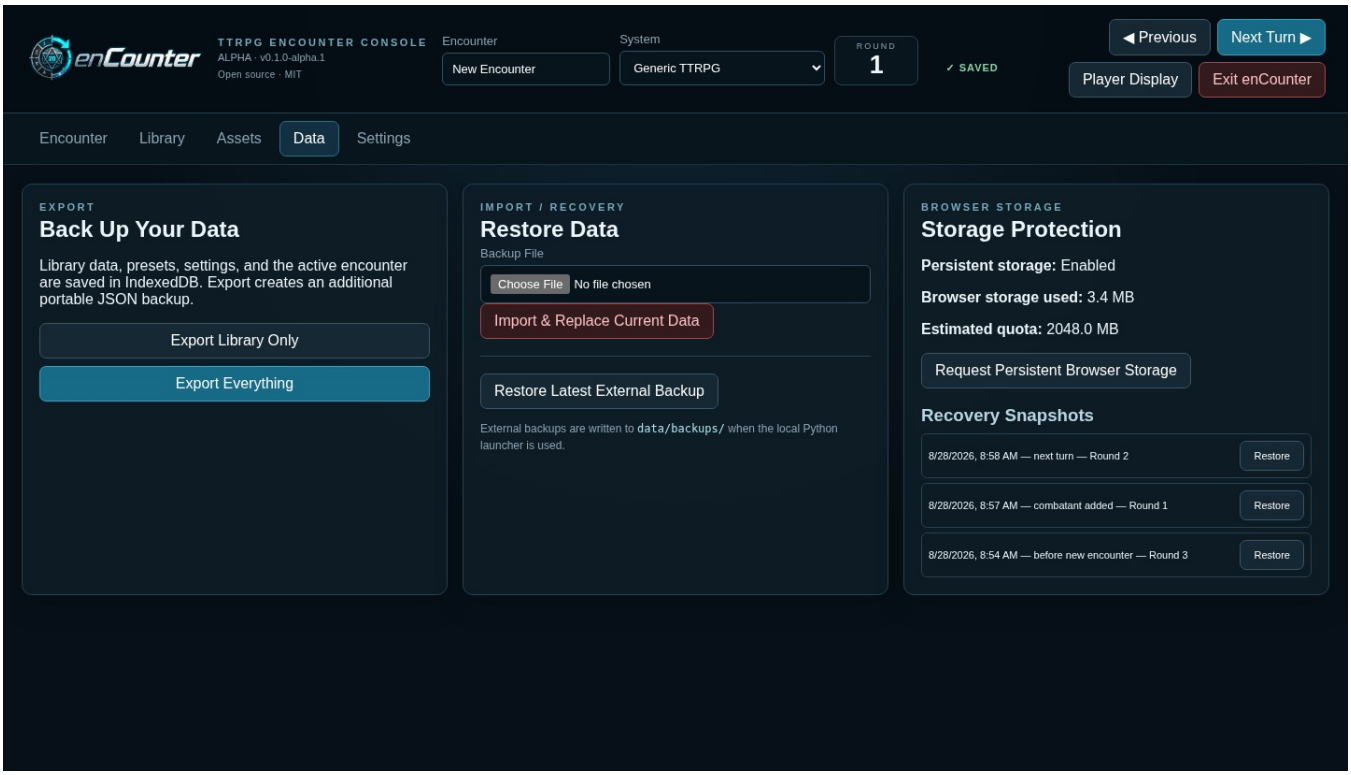


Figure 8 - Data screen for export, import, external backup recovery, and browser storage.

12.1 Understand the storage layers

> Saved Encounter records include their Scene/Combat image references, Soundscape configuration, prepared cue assignments, and other encounter settings. The JSON backup/export stores those references and settings, but it does not embed the actual image or audio files.

When moving enCounter to another computer, copy the assets/ folder as well as restoring the JSON backup. Audio files under assets/sounds/ and images under assets/backgrounds/ remain ordinary files in the portable enCounter folder.

Layer	What it contains	Where it lives
Browser working database	Library, active working encounter, Saved Encounters, presets, Soundscape configuration, settings, snapshots, metadata	IndexedDB in the browser profile (enCounterAlphaDB)
Automatic external backup	Library, encounters/Saved Encounters/presets, Soundscape configuration, settings, metadata; does not include browser recovery snapshots or media files	data/backups/ inside the portable enCounter folder

Layer	What it contains	Where it lives
Manual Export Everything	Portable full JSON backup including browser recovery snapshots	Your browser Downloads folder unless you choose another download location
Manual Export Library Only	Permanent Library records only	Your browser Downloads folder
Local media assets	Portraits, backgrounds, music, ambience, sound effects, and other imported media	assets/ inside the portable enCounter folder; copy this folder separately when moving installations

12.2 Automatic external backup

With automatic external backups enabled, enCounter writes data/backups/backup-latest.json after scheduled saves. Approximately once per hour, it can also create a timestamped backup-YYYYMMDD-HHMMSSZ.json history file. The launcher keeps up to 20 of these hourly history files.

> **IMPORTANT:** Automatic external backup is an additional recovery layer, not the working database. Do not rely on only one copy of important campaign data.

12.3 Export Library Only

1. Open Data.
2. Click Export Library Only.
3. The browser downloads a file similar to enCounter-Library-2026-08-28.json.
4. Store the file somewhere safe or copy it with your campaign backups.

Importing a Library-only export through the Data screen replaces the current permanent Library but does not replace the active encounter, presets, or settings.

12.4 Export Everything

1. Open Data.
2. Click Export Everything.
3. The browser downloads a file similar to enCounter-Backup-2026-08-28.json.
4. Use this option before changing computers, testing a new Alpha version, or making a major campaign change.

Export Everything includes the Library, encounters, encounter presets, settings, metadata, and browser recovery snapshots.

12.5 Export a single Library entry

On a Library card, click Export to download only that one entry. A single-entry JSON can be imported later without clearing the rest of the Library.

12.6 Import and Replace Current Data

1. Open Data.
2. Choose the desired JSON file under Backup File.
3. Click Import & Replace Current Data.
4. Read the confirmation message carefully and continue only if the selected file is correct.
5. After import, enCounter reloads settings, Library data, the active encounter, assets, snapshots, and storage status.

> **CAUTION:** A full backup import replaces the current application data. A Library-only import replaces the current Library. A single-entry export adds or updates only that one entry. Export the current state first if you might need to undo the import.

12.7 Restore Latest External Backup

Restore Latest External Backup reads data/backups/backup-latest.json and replaces the current browser data with that disk backup. Because automatic external backups intentionally omit browser recovery snapshots, restoring one may clear the current browser snapshot history.

12.8 Recovery snapshots

enCounter creates browser recovery snapshots at key encounter transitions, such as adding/removing combatants, changing combat states, moving turns, loading presets, changing systems, or starting a new encounter. The Data screen lists available snapshots with a Restore button.

1. Open Data.
2. Find the desired snapshot by date/time, reason, and round.
3. Click Restore.
4. Confirm the restore.
5. The snapshot replaces the active encounter only; the permanent Library is not changed.

12.9 Request Persistent Browser Storage

Click Request Persistent Browser Storage to ask the browser to protect enCounter storage from routine eviction. The browser decides whether to grant the request. This is useful but does not replace manual exports or disk backups.

13. Moving enCounter to Another Computer or USB

enCounter is portable, but its browser IndexedDB does not automatically travel with the application folder. Physical assets and JSON backup files do travel when you copy the folder.

13.1 Recommended transfer procedure

> Because audio and image assets are stored as files rather than inside the JSON export, transfer the complete assets/ folder with the enCounter installation. Restoring Export Everything without the referenced media files can leave Saved Encounters intact while their images or audio selections point to missing assets.

1. On the original computer, open Data and click Export Everything.
2. Copy the exported JSON into a safe location. You may place a copy under data/exports/ if you want it to travel with the portable folder.
3. Use Exit enCounter so the local process releases the folder.
4. Copy the entire enCounter portable folder to the USB drive or destination computer.
5. On the new computer, run enCounter from the copied folder.
6. Open Data, select the Export Everything JSON, and use Import & Replace Current Data.
7. Confirm portraits/backgrounds are available; these physical files should already have traveled with assets/.

> **TIP:** Running from a USB drive is possible, but copying the folder to the local computer first is generally safer and faster. Avoid disconnecting removable storage while enCounter is writing an asset or backup.

14. Exiting enCounter Correctly

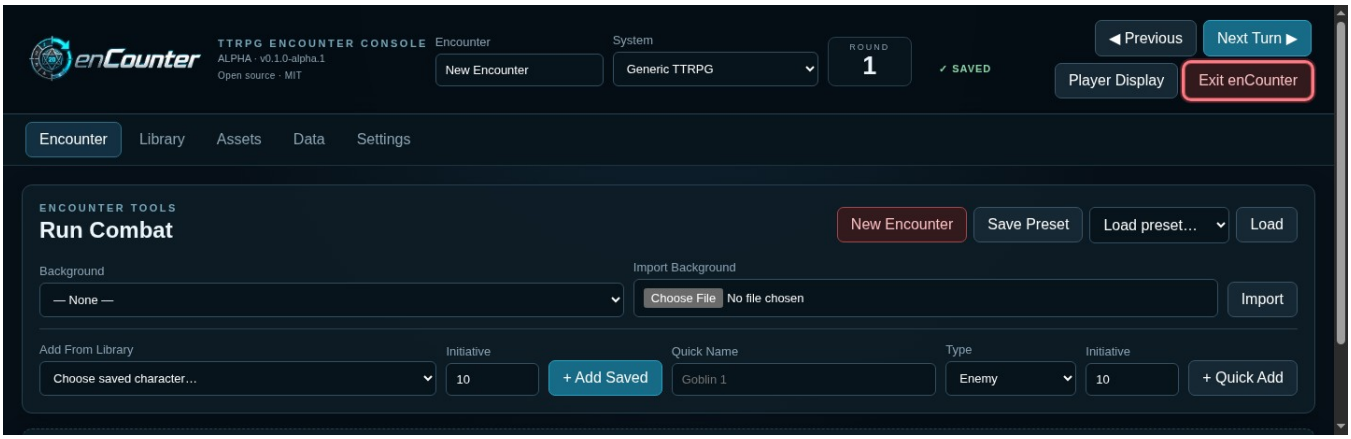


Figure 9 - Exit enCounter stops the local background server; closing only the browser may not.

Closing the browser tab does not necessarily stop enCounter.exe or the Linux enCounter process. The browser is only the interface; the local server can continue running in the background and may keep the application folder in use.

1. Finish the current action and wait until the header shows ✓ SAVED.
2. Click Exit enCounter in the DM Console.
3. Confirm the exit prompt.
4. If automatic external backups are enabled, enCounter attempts one final external backup.
5. The app sends a shutdown request to the local server and displays a stopped message.
6. Close the browser tab/window after the shutdown completes.

> **IMPORTANT:** Always use Exit enCounter before deleting, replacing, renaming, or moving the application folder.

15. Recommended Game-Session Workflow

Before the session:

1. Create or load the encounter working copy and choose the correct game system.
2. Add reusable Library combatants and any quick-added encounter-only participants.
3. Choose the Scene Image and Combat Background.
4. Open Soundscape, import/select scene ambience and music, configure combat audio, set fade behavior, and prepare cue sounds. Click Apply to Encounter.
5. Configure any timer settings you expect to use.
6. Use Save As… for a new reusable encounter or Save to update an existing Saved Encounter.

During the session:

7. Load the Saved Encounter. Keep the Player Display on STAND BY while making private final adjustments.
8. Use Scene Audio when you want ambience to begin. Use Show Scene when you want players to see roleplaying artwork. These actions are independent.
9. Start and show visual timers for non-combat events when appropriate.
10. Trigger Prepared Cues directly from the Encounter tab as needed.
11. When combat begins, use Start Combat. Confirm the Player Display changes to Combat mode and, when configured, scene audio fades/ducks while combat audio begins.
12. Run initiative with Previous/Next Turn and the combatant controls. Confirm that the DM Console follows the active combatant and the Player Display centers the current visible combatant as turns advance.
13. Use End Combat to return to Scene mode when appropriate; scene audio can return automatically if enabled.
14. At important milestones, use Data → Export Everything. At the end of the session, wait for ✓ SAVED and click Exit enCounter.

16. Troubleshooting

16.1 Windows says the enCounter folder is in use

The local enCounter process may still be running because the browser was closed without using Exit enCounter.

1. Close any VS Code or File Explorer window that is actively using the old folder.

2. Open Task Manager with Ctrl + Shift + Esc.

3. Look for enCounter.exe. Older development copies may instead show python.exe or pythonw.exe.

4. End only the stale enCounter process associated with the old copy.

5. Try deleting or renaming the folder again.

16.2 enCounter cannot start because port 5500 is in use

Another enCounter instance or development server may still be listening on port 5500. Close the old instance using Exit enCounter or end the stale process, then start enCounter again.

16.3 Player Display says DISCONNECTED

- Open the Player Display using the button in the DM Console.
- Keep DM and Player Display in the same browser profile.
- Do not use one browser for the DM and another browser for the Player Display.
- Do not use a private/incognito Player Display when the DM uses the normal browser profile.
- Keep the DM Console open.

16.4 Player Display shows STAND BY

STAND BY is the Player Display privacy screen. It is expected while the display is first connecting and whenever the DM has clicked Hide Player Display.

If the DM intends the encounter to be visible, click Show Player Display in the DM header. The current encounter should appear immediately using the latest synchronized state.

If STAND BY remains after clicking Show Player Display, confirm DM SYNC is CONNECTED and that both windows are using the same browser profile.

16.5 A Library entry does not appear under Add From Library

The encounter and Library entry systems must match. Check the active System in the DM header and the saved System on the Library entry.

16.6 Assets are not listed

- Confirm the file is PNG, JPEG/JPG, or WebP.
- Confirm the file is in a supported subfolder under assets/.
- Click Assets → Refresh after copying files manually.
- If importing through the UI, keep images at 10 MB or less.

16.7 Data appears missing on another computer

Browser IndexedDB is local to the browser profile and does not move just because the enCounter folder was copied. Restore an Export Everything backup on the new computer.

16.8 Restore or import reports an incompatible backup

A backup created by a newer database schema cannot be imported by an older enCounter build. Update enCounter to a compatible/newer version, then retry the import.

16.9 Linux reports permission denied

Run chmod +x enCounter in a terminal, then start it with ./enCounter.

16.10 Audio does not start

Browser audio normally requires a user action. Click Scene Audio, Combat, or a cue button again. Confirm the selected asset still exists, the Master Volume and track volume are above zero, and Windows/Linux is using the intended output device. Audio plays from the DM computer; it is not duplicated by the Player Display.

16.11 A Saved Encounter loads but audio or images are missing

The Saved Encounter stores references to media files, not the media bytes themselves. Confirm the referenced files exist under assets/backgrounds/ or assets/sounds/. If the installation was moved, copy the complete assets/ folder from the original installation.

16.12 Prepared Cue buttons are missing from Encounter

Open Soundscape, assign a name and audio asset to the cue, click Apply to Encounter, then Save the Saved Encounter if you want that cue configuration preserved for future loads. Empty cue slots are not shown on the Encounter tab.

16.13 DM Auto-Follow does not bring the current combatant into view

Confirm that the action actually changed the current turn. Auto-Follow is expected after Start Combat, Next Turn, Previous, Set Turn, or Trigger / Resume when it takes the turn. Ordinary HP/status/resource edits do not trigger Auto-Follow by design.

If the current card is highlighted but does not move into view, reload the DM Console and confirm you are running the v0.2.0-alpha.2 build rather than an older portable copy or cached page.

16.14 Player Display current combatant is not centered

Confirm the Player Display is in Combat mode, DM SYNC is CONNECTED, and the combatant is visible to players. Hidden combatants are intentionally omitted. Advance the turn once with Next Turn to confirm that the current visible card recenters.

16.15 Browser still shows an older version or interface after updating

Cache clearing is not normally required when updating enCounter. Use the following steps only if you have installed and started the new build but the browser still shows an older version number, missing new controls, or the previous interface.

1. Confirm that you started enCounter from the new release folder. If an older DM Console is still open, use Exit enCounter and close the Player Display and remaining enCounter tabs. If port 5500 is still in use, follow section 16.2 to stop the stale process.

2. Start the new build again and confirm the expected version is shown in the DM Console header.

3. Try a normal refresh first (Ctrl + R). If the old interface remains, use a hard refresh: Ctrl + Shift + R on Windows/Linux, or Command + Shift + R on macOS.

4. Only if the hard refresh does not resolve the stale interface, clear cached images/files for the browser and reopen enCounter. Do not select cookies, site data, local storage, or IndexedDB as part of routine cache troubleshooting.

> CAUTION: Clearing site data or IndexedDB can remove the browser-stored enCounter Library, Saved Encounters, settings, and current working data. If a factory-reset-level clear is intentionally necessary, create an Export Everything backup first.

5. If the old version still appears, an older enCounter executable/server is probably still running or the previous installation was launched. Recheck the running process and release folder before changing browser storage.

17. Visual Timers

Visual Timers are independent of initiative and can be used during roleplaying scenes or combat. The timer engine uses absolute system time so browser rendering delays do not make the countdown drift.

17.1 Create and start a timer

1. Open Timer from the DM Console navigation.

2. Enter a Timer Name and set Minutes and Seconds.

3. Choose Fantasy Hourglass, Candle, or Sci-Fi Pixel Sequence.

4. Choose Overlay, Featured, or Focus for the Player Display.

5. Choose whether to Show timer to players, Show exact countdown to players, and Show exact countdown in DM preview.

6. Click Start. Use Pause, Resume, Reset, Stop, or the ±10 second / ±1 minute controls as required.

> The timer remains available in both Scene and Combat presentation. While the Player Display is on STAND BY, the timer is hidden from players.

17.2 Player Display behavior

Overlay keeps the timer as a secondary visual over the current scene or combat display. Featured gives the timer more visual emphasis. Focus is intended for situations where the countdown itself should dominate the player presentation.

The numeric countdown is optional. Hiding the numeric value allows the visual skin itself to communicate urgency without revealing the exact remaining time.

[SCREENSHOT PLACEHOLDER] Capture the Timer tab showing a short timer, the selected skin, Player Display options, and the DM preview.

Figure 12 - Timer tab and visual timer controls.

17.3 Saved Encounter Timer configuration

A Saved Encounter now preserves the prepared Timer configuration: Timer Name, configured duration, selected visual skin, Player Display mode, whether the timer is shown to players, and the DM/player numeric-countdown preferences. Configure the timer as part of encounter preparation, then use Encounter → Save or Save As… to preserve those settings with the reusable encounter.

> IMPORTANT: Only the prepared Timer configuration is reusable encounter data. Loading a Saved Encounter resets the timer to Ready at its full configured duration. Running, paused, completed, current remaining time, and live end-time state are intentionally not restored from an earlier session.

18. Soundscape, Audio, and Prepared Cues

Soundscape belongs to the currently loaded encounter. It is designed for preparation before game night: scene ambience, combat audio, transition behavior, and one-shot cues can be configured in advance and stored with the Saved Encounter.

18.1 Import audio

1. Open Soundscape.

2. Under Import Audio, choose Music, Ambience, Sound Effects, or Custom.

3. Choose an MP3, OGG, WAV, or FLAC file and click Import Audio.

4. The imported file is copied into the matching assets/sounds/ folder and becomes available to Soundscape selectors.

18.2 Configure Scene Audio

Scene Audio is for roleplaying and exploration before or between combats. Configure optional Scene Music and up to three Ambient Layers. Examples include a busy market, night forest, campfire, cantina, rain, starship engines, machinery, or crowd noise.

For each ambience layer choose what should happen when combat begins: Lower Volume, Continue, or Stop. Lower Volume uses the Combat % value to duck the ambience behind combat music.

18.3 Configure Combat Audio

Configure Combat Music and optional Combat Ambience layers. Enable Switch to combat audio when combat starts when you want Start Combat to perform the transition automatically. Enable Return to scene audio when combat ends when End Combat should restore the scene Soundscape.

18.4 Master volume and fade

Master Volume scales the complete Soundscape. Fade controls the transition time when tracks start, stop, or change between Scene and Combat. Use Stop on the Soundscape or Stop Audio on Encounter for immediate control when needed.

18.5 Prepared Cues

Up to three prepared one-shot cues can be assigned in the Soundscape editor. Give each cue a descriptive name, choose an audio asset, and set its volume. The Play buttons on Soundscape can preview the cues. After Apply to Encounter, configured cues also appear as live buttons on the Encounter tab so the DM does not need to leave the main game screen.

Prepared cues can be triggered during either Scene or Combat. Typical uses include alarms, doors, explosions, creature calls, radio transmissions, weapon effects, horns, or environmental events.

18.6 Save and load a Soundscape

> There is no separate Soundscape Library. The Soundscape is part of the current encounter. Click Apply to Encounter to update the working encounter, then use Encounter → Save or Save As… to preserve it as a

reusable Saved Encounter. Loading that Saved Encounter later restores its Soundscape configuration and prepared cues automatically.

Audio playback state itself is not a permanent saved state: loading an encounter does not force audio to start. The DM chooses Scene Audio or Start Combat when ready.

[SCREENSHOT PLACEHOLDER] Capture the Soundscape tab showing Scene Audio, Combat Audio, Prepared Cues, master volume/fade, and Import Audio.

Figure 13 - Soundscape configuration for a prepared encounter.

Appendix A - Mode and Module Reference

Module	Simple	Standard	Advanced
HP Tracking	Off	On	On
Visible Status Effects	Off	On	On
Conditions / Condition Track	Off	Off	On
System Statistics	Off	On	On
Abilities	Off	Off	On
Resources	Off	Off	On
Private DM Notes	Off	On	On
Hidden Combatants	Off	On	On
Damage / Healing & Combat Controls	Off	On	On
Encounter Backgrounds	On	On	On
Encounter Presets	Off	On	On

Custom mode is created automatically when you change individual module checkboxes and can contain any combination of the modules above.

Appendix B - Data and File Reference

Item	Typical location / filename	Purpose
Working browser DB	IndexedDB: enCounterAlphaDB	Primary active working data
Latest automatic backup	data/backups/backup-latest.json	Most recent automatic disk backup
Hourly backup history	data/backups/backup-YYYYMMDD-HHMMSSZ.json	Rotating external history, up to 20 files
Full manual export	enCounter-Backup-YYYY-MM-DD.json	Portable backup including browser snapshots

Item	Typical location / filename	Purpose
Library manual export	enCounter-Library-YYYY-MM-DD.json	Portable permanent Library only
Single Library export	<entry-name>.json	One reusable Library record
User backgrounds	assets/backgrounds/...	Player Display encounter backgrounds
User portraits	assets/portraits/...	Reusable character/enemy portraits
Saved Encounters	IndexedDB encounter records / JSON backups	Reusable prepared encounter templates including Soundscape configuration and media references
User audio	assets/sounds/music, ambience, sfx, custom	Local music, ambience, and sound-effect files; not embedded in JSON exports

Appendix C - License, Privacy, and AI Disclosure

enCounter v0.2.0-alpha.2 is distributed under the MIT License. The application includes a legal/notices link in the DM Console and Player Display. The portable distribution also contains LICENSE and THIRD_PARTY_NOTICES.md.

enCounter is local-first. The Alpha server binds to 127.0.0.1 and is designed to keep encounter, Library, and campaign data on the local computer unless the user deliberately copies or shares an export or asset.

The project includes an AI_ASSISTANCE.md disclosure. Generative AI tools assisted with coding, debugging, documentation, project organization, testing suggestions, and release preparation. The current application does not itself contain generative-AI functionality and does not intentionally send campaign data to an AI service.

> **NOTE:** Third-party game names, systems, products, companies, and trademarks remain the property of their respective owners. References in enCounter are for identification or compatibility and do not imply endorsement, sponsorship, or affiliation.

Quick Reference - End of Session

Before you close	Recommended action
1	Wait for ✓ SAVED.
2	Optionally use Data → Export Everything for a milestone backup.
3	Click Exit enCounter.
4	Wait for the stopped/shutdown confirmation.
5	Close the browser.
6	Only then move, replace, or delete the enCounter folder.